GMAX DIGITAL SOLUTIONS PRESENTS

THE E-COMMERCE AI VISIBILITY PLAYBOOK

7 Strategies to Get Found on Google AND AI Search Before Your Competitors Do

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For UK e-commerce brands doing £500K–£10M in annual revenue who are tired of paying for traffic they should already own.

Informed by the frameworks from:
Traction · Weinberg & Mares
The 1-Page Marketing Plan · Allan Dib

A Note Before We Start

If you are running a UK e-commerce brand and spending thousands every month on Google Ads and Meta Ads just to keep sales moving — this guide was written for you.

You already know what the problem feels like. Ad costs are rising. Margins are tightening. And every month that ticks by is another month your competitors are building organic visibility you are not.

But here is the part most e-commerce founders do not know yet: there is a second search engine eating your traffic, and it is growing faster than Google.

It is called AI search. ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google's AI Overviews, Gemini. Your customers are already using these tools to find products, compare brands, and make purchase decisions. The brands that appear in those AI answers are winning. The ones that do not exist on AI search are invisible to an increasingly large segment of their market.

This playbook gives you 7 strategies to fix both problems — Google visibility and AI search visibility — before your competitors do. Each strategy comes with specific, actionable steps you can implement immediately.

WHO THIS IS FOR

UK e-commerce brands turning over £500K–£10M annually, selling physical products in fashion, home goods, health & beauty, or pet products. You are currently spending money on paid ads. You want to reduce that dependency. You have been burned by a generic agency before that promised rankings and delivered nothing measurable.

THE CENTRAL INSIGHT

Most e-commerce SEO guides are still written for 2019. They talk about keywords and backlinks. That still matters — but the game has changed. In 2026, winning organic visibility means optimising for two entirely different discovery systems simultaneously: traditional search engines and AI-powered answer engines. This guide shows you how.

The Visibility Crisis Hitting UK E-Commerce Right Now

Let us start with what is actually happening, because the numbers are alarming.

The Search Landscape Has Fractured

For the past decade, e-commerce SEO meant one thing: rank on Google. Get to page one, capture the click, make the sale. It was complicated, but at least it was a single game with known rules.

That single game is now two games running simultaneously.

Game one is still Google — 90%+ of traditional search still flows through it, and page-one rankings still generate significant commercial value. If you are not on page one for your key product and category terms, you are leaving substantial revenue on the table.

Game two is AI search — and it is growing at a pace that is genuinely alarming for brands that are not paying attention. ChatGPT reached 100 million users faster than any platform in history. Perplexity is processing hundreds of millions of queries per month. Google's own AI Overviews now appear on the majority of commercial search queries, pushing organic results further down the page.

Here is the problem: ranking on Google does not guarantee you appear in AI answers. The algorithms are different. The content requirements are different. The trust signals are different. You need both — and most e-commerce brands have neither.

The Two Search Games	What It Means For Your Brand
Traditional Google SEO	Page-one rankings for product and category keywords. Still the highest-volume channel. Slower to build but durable once established.
AI Search Visibility (AEO)	Your brand and products being recommended by ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Google AI Overviews. Fastest-growing discovery channel. Almost zero competition yet — most brands are ignoring it.
The Brands Winning	Optimising for both simultaneously. Appearing in traditional results AND AI answers for the same queries. Compounding traffic without increasing ad spend.
The Brands Losing	Still 100% dependent on paid ads. Invisible on Google for organic terms. Do not even know if they appear in AI answers. Ad costs rising every quarter.

Why UK E-Commerce Brands Are Especially Exposed

The UK e-commerce market is worth $317 billion in 2026. Fashion alone accounts for £67.8 billion in online sales. 62 million UK consumers shop online. This is a massive, growing market — which also means it is a fiercely competitive one.

In a competitive market, organic visibility is not a nice-to-have. It is a survival strategy. The brands that own organic search are not dependent on ad spend to survive a bad quarter. They

are not caught off-guard when Meta changes its algorithm or Google adjusts its ad pricing. They have built an asset — traffic they own, not traffic they rent.

Right now, most UK e-commerce brands are entirely in the rented traffic camp. They know it. They do not like it. And they are looking for a way out.

These 7 strategies are that way out.

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Strategy 1

Audit Your Current Visibility Gap

You cannot fix what you cannot see

Every strategy in this playbook starts from the same place: knowing exactly where you are invisible and where you are visible. Without this baseline, you are optimising in the dark.

Most e-commerce brands are surprised by what a proper visibility audit reveals. Brands that think they have decent SEO discover they are ranking on page three for their most valuable product terms. Brands that have never thought about AI search discover they do not appear in a single ChatGPT response for queries their customers are making daily.

The Two-Part Visibility Audit

Part 1: Google Visibility Snapshot

Start by establishing where you currently rank for the queries that drive commercial value for your business. You are looking for three things:

- Your position for your top 10 product and category keywords (the terms that, if you ranked on page one, would drive significant buying traffic)
- The gap between where you are and where your top 2–3 competitors are ranking for the same terms
- The estimated monthly search volume for each term — so you can prioritise by revenue potential, not just ranking difficulty

Free tools that help with this: Google Search Console (shows your current rankings), Ubersuggest or Moz Free (shows competitor rankings and search volumes), and Google's own 'People also ask' feature (reveals adjacent queries you may be missing entirely).

Part 2: AI Search Visibility Check

This is the part most brands have never done. Open ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Google AI Overviews and run the following tests:

1. Search for '[your product category] UK' — does your brand appear in any AI answer?
2. Search for 'best [your product type] brands UK' — are you mentioned?
3. Search for '[specific product name you sell] review' — does AI mention you at all?
4. Search for a question your customers commonly ask about your product category — whose brand does AI recommend?

Write down the results. You now know your AI search visibility baseline — likely zero or near-zero, which is where most e-commerce brands currently stand.

THE MOST COMMON FINDING

Brands doing £2M–£5M in annual e-commerce revenue with an active SEO spend are frequently invisible on AI search entirely. Not partially visible — completely absent. A competitor spending half their budget but structured correctly for AEO is capturing a growing share of AI-referred traffic that the larger brand is not even measuring.

What To Do With Your Audit Results

Once you have your visibility snapshot, you have a prioritised action list. For Google: focus on the high-volume, high-commercial-intent keywords where you are ranking on pages two or three — these are the easiest wins. For AI search: identify the question-based queries in your category and the product recommendation queries. These are your AI content targets.

Action Checklist: Strategy 1

1. Run your Google ranking snapshot for top 10 product/category keywords using Search Console.
2. Check 3–5 competitor rankings for the same terms.
3. Run the AI visibility test across ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Google AI Overviews.
4. Document your findings in a simple spreadsheet: keyword, your rank, competitor rank, AI visibility (yes/no).

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Strategy 2

Understand How AI Search Works — And Why It Changes Everything

The new game has new rules

Before you can optimise for AI search, you need to understand what AI search actually is and how it decides what to recommend. This is not technical — it is strategic.

Traditional Search vs AI Search: The Core Difference

Traditional Google works by matching keywords in a query to keywords on a page. You optimise your product page for 'women's leather handbags UK,' Google finds your page, checks your authority, and decides where to rank you. The game is about relevance + authority + technical health.

AI search works differently. When someone asks ChatGPT 'what is the best UK brand for sustainable women's handbags under £200,' ChatGPT is not just doing keyword matching. It is drawing on its training data, live web results (in GPT-4 with browsing), and its understanding of which brands are trusted, discussed, and recommended across the internet.

To appear in AI answers, you need to be present across the sources AI tools draw from — not just your own website.

What Influences AI Search Results	How You Build It
Being mentioned in credible editorial content	PR coverage, guest posts on relevant industry sites, journalist mentions
Appearing in review sites and aggregators	Trustpilot, Google Reviews, Feefo, industry comparison sites
Having structured, clear product and brand information	Schema markup, clear product descriptions, FAQ pages
Being cited in 'best of' and roundup content	Listicles, gift guides, category roundups on authoritative sites
Having a topically authoritative presence	A body of helpful, expert content on your product category
Social proof and mention volume	Being talked about across Reddit, social media, forums in your niche

Answer Engine Optimisation (AEO): The New Discipline

Answer Engine Optimisation is the practice of structuring your brand presence so that AI tools recognise you as a credible, relevant recommendation for specific queries. It is not a replacement for SEO — it runs alongside it. In fact, many of the activities that build your Google rankings also build your AI visibility: quality content, editorial coverage, strong reviews, clear brand identity.

The difference is intent and structure. Traditional SEO optimises your site for crawlers. AEO optimises your brand presence — across your site, third-party sites, social platforms, and review networks — for AI understanding.

WHY THIS MATTERS RIGHT NOW

AI search is still early. Most UK e-commerce brands are not optimising for it. The brands that build AEO authority now will own those AI recommendations by the time the channel matures. This is the same opportunity that existed with Google SEO in 2010 — the brands that moved early own the prime positions. The window is open. It will not stay open.

Action Checklist: Strategy 2

1. Understand the difference: Google SEO = on-site optimisation. AEO = brand presence across the wider web.
2. Identify the five most valuable 'recommendation queries' in your category — the questions AI users ask to find brands like yours.
3. Check which competitors appear in AI answers for those queries. This is your competitive benchmark.

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Strategy 3

Restructure Your Product and Category Pages for Both Audiences

One page. Two algorithms. Double the visibility.

Your product and category pages are doing double duty in 2026. They need to satisfy Google's ranking algorithm AND provide the kind of clear, structured, trustworthy information that AI systems pull into their answers.

The good news: these goals are more aligned than they appear. Both Google and AI search reward the same fundamental qualities — clarity, depth, structure, and trustworthiness. The difference is in the details of how you implement them.

The Anatomy of a High-Performing E-Commerce Page in 2026

For Google: Technical and Relevance Fundamentals

- Primary keyword in the H1, URL, and first 100 words of copy
- Secondary and semantic keywords naturally woven into product descriptions and category introductions
- Fast page load speed — especially on mobile (Core Web Vitals are a ranking factor)
- Internal links connecting category pages to relevant product pages and blog content
- Structured data markup (schema) for products: price, availability, reviews, brand

For AI Search: Structured Information and Entity Clarity

- A clear, direct answer to the most common question about this product category in the first paragraph
- FAQ section on category and product pages addressing the questions buyers ask before purchasing
- Explicit brand mention and brand story — AI systems need to understand who you are as an entity
- Review integration and star ratings visible on the page — AI trusts social proof heavily
- Comparison information: why your product vs the alternatives? AI recommendation queries often have a 'best' or 'versus' intent

THE SINGLE MOST UNDERUSED ELEMENT ON E-COMMERCE PAGES

FAQ sections. Most e-commerce brands treat product pages as glorified brochures. A FAQ section on your category page that answers 8–10 real questions buyers have (How long does delivery take? What is your returns policy? Is this product suitable for sensitive skin? How does this compare to Brand X?) is one of the most powerful dual-optimisation moves available. Google features FAQ schema in search results. AI systems pull FAQ answers into their responses. It takes two hours to add. Most brands have not done it.

The Brand Page Problem

Many e-commerce brands do not have a dedicated 'About' page that clearly establishes who they are, what they stand for, what products they specialise in, and why customers trust them. This is a significant AI visibility gap.

AI systems need to understand your brand as an entity — not just as a collection of product pages. A well-written, specific About page that includes your founding story, your specialism, your values, and your customer base gives AI systems the information they need to confidently recommend you.

Action Checklist: Strategy 3

1. Audit your top 5 product and category pages against the dual-optimisation checklist above.
2. Add FAQ sections to your top 3 category pages this month.
3. Implement Product schema markup on all product pages (use Google's Rich Results Test to check).
4. Rewrite or create a proper About page that establishes your brand as a specific, trustworthy entity.

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Strategy 4

Build Topical Authority in Your Category

Be the brand AI thinks of first when your topic comes up

Here is the question that should guide your content strategy: in your product category, is your brand the go-to authoritative voice? Would Google — and would ChatGPT — look at the content landscape and say 'this brand clearly knows more about this topic than anyone else'?

For most e-commerce brands, the honest answer is no. They have a blog with a handful of posts, some of which are product-adjacent, most of which are generic. Their competitors look the same. Nobody is the authority. That gap is your opportunity.

What Topical Authority Actually Means

Topical authority is the accumulated signal — across your website and across the wider web — that your brand deeply understands a specific subject area. Google's algorithm increasingly rewards topical depth over keyword density. AI systems, trained on the body of available content, favour brands that show up comprehensively on a topic.

For a UK brand selling sustainable women's fashion, topical authority means being the brand that has covered sustainable fabrics, ethical manufacturing certifications, how to care for sustainable garments, the environmental cost of fast fashion, and what questions to ask before buying sustainable clothing. Not one post. Not five. A genuine, comprehensive body of work.

The Content Cluster Model for E-Commerce

The most efficient way to build topical authority is through content clusters — a pillar page supported by a web of more specific content pieces, all internally linked.

Content Tier	What It Covers
Pillar page	A comprehensive guide to your core category topic (2,000–3,000 words). Example: 'The Complete Guide to Sustainable Women's Fashion in the UK'
Cluster content — buying guides	Specific purchase decision content. 'How to Choose the Right [Product] for [Use Case]'. Targets mid-funnel queries.
Cluster content — comparison	Brand and product comparisons. 'X vs Y: Which is Better for [Specific Need]?'. High AI recommendation query value.
Cluster content — problem/solution	Answers specific pain points. 'Why Does My [Product] Do X and How Do I Fix It?'. High question-intent traffic.
Cluster content — 'best of' roundups	'Best [Product Category] in the UK 2026'. These are the pages that AI pulls from for recommendation queries.

All cluster content links back to the pillar page. The pillar page links out to relevant cluster pieces. Google sees a coherent, comprehensive topic treatment. AI systems see a brand that has covered this category in depth. Both reward you with visibility.

THE SHORTCUT BRANDS ARE MISSING

> Most e-commerce brands wait until they have spare marketing budget to 'do content.' That is backwards. Content is the cheapest, most durable investment you can make in your marketing infrastructure. A well-structured pillar page written today still drives traffic in three years. The £500 Google Ad you ran last Tuesday is already gone. Start with one pillar page. Do it well. Then build the cluster.

Action Checklist: Strategy 4

1. Choose one core topic area for your topical authority strategy — your most commercially valuable product category.
2. Map out a content cluster: one pillar page, five supporting cluster posts.
3. Publish the pillar page first — it anchors everything else.
4. Use your audit from Strategy 1 to identify which specific questions buyers are asking in your category. These become your cluster content titles.

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Strategy 5

Get Mentioned Where AI Looks

Your brand's reputation on the wider web is your AI search fuel

Your website is only one input into how AI systems understand and recommend your brand. What is written about you on other websites — review platforms, editorial sites, industry publications, comparison sites, social forums — carries enormous weight in AI's assessment of your credibility and relevance.

This is the most overlooked dimension of AI search for e-commerce brands. You can have a perfectly optimised website and still be invisible on AI search if nobody on the wider web is talking about you.

The Digital PR Imperative

Digital PR — getting your brand mentioned in credible, relevant online publications — is not a luxury for large brands. It is the engine of AI search visibility for any e-commerce brand that wants to be recommended.

When a journalist writes 'Gmax Digital Solutions helped us understand the difference between SEO and AI search' and that article is published on a relevant industry site, that mention becomes part of the data landscape AI systems draw from. Multiply that across ten, twenty, fifty mentions in credible publications and your brand becomes an entity that AI systems confidently recognise and recommend.

Practical Digital PR for E-Commerce Brands

- Product seeding: send your hero products to relevant UK bloggers, journalists, and content creators in your category. Gifting that generates genuine coverage is one of the highest-ROI AI visibility investments available.
- Expert commentary: contact journalists covering your product category and offer to be quoted as a brand expert. 'We are the founder of [Brand], we can comment on [specific trend].' This generates editorial mentions that carry significant authority.
- Industry roundups and gift guides: proactively pitch your products to editors putting together 'best of' and gift guide content. These are the exact page types AI pulls from for recommendation queries.
- HARO (Help A Reporter Out): this free service connects journalists looking for expert sources with brands and individuals who can comment. A reply that gets used generates a quality editorial backlink and brand mention.

The Review Platform Problem

AI systems weight review platforms heavily when assessing brand trustworthiness. Trustpilot, Google Reviews, Feefo, and category-specific review sites are direct inputs into AI's understanding of whether customers trust you.

Most e-commerce brands have a passive review strategy: they wait for customers to leave reviews and hope for the best. A proactive review strategy — systematically asking satisfied customers for reviews at the right moment, responding to negative reviews constructively, and actively managing your presence on key review platforms — builds the social proof that AI search requires.

THE COMPOUND EFFECT

Each editorial mention, each review, each forum discussion that mentions your brand adds to the cumulative signal that AI systems use to decide whether to recommend you. This is not a quick win — it is an infrastructure investment. But brands that start building this signal today will own AI search recommendations in their categories by 2027. Brands that wait will find the positions already taken.

Action Checklist: Strategy 5

1. Identify the top 10 UK publications, blogs, and content platforms in your product category.
2. Develop a digital PR outreach list and send five personalised pitches per month.
3. Set up a systematic review request process — email every customer 14 days after purchase asking for a Trustpilot review.
4. Register for HARO alerts in your product category and respond to relevant journalist queries.

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Strategy 6

Implement Technical SEO That Protects Your Foundation

You cannot rank on a broken website

All the content strategy in the world is undermined if your website has technical problems that prevent Google from crawling, indexing, and ranking it correctly. Technical SEO is not glamorous — but it is foundational, and it is an area where many e-commerce brands have accumulated significant problems they are unaware of.

The Technical SEO Checklist for E-Commerce

Site Speed and Core Web Vitals

Google uses Core Web Vitals as a ranking factor — specifically Largest Contentful Paint (how fast your main content loads), Cumulative Layout Shift (how stable the page is as it loads), and Interaction to Next Paint (how fast the page responds to user interaction).

E-commerce sites routinely fail Core Web Vitals because of large uncompressed images, too many third-party scripts, and poorly structured JavaScript. Use Google PageSpeed Insights to check your scores. Anything below 50 on mobile is damaging your rankings.

Crawlability and Index Health

- Check Google Search Console for crawl errors — pages Google tried and failed to access
- Ensure your robots.txt file is not accidentally blocking important pages from being crawled
- Check that your XML sitemap is up to date and submitted to Google Search Console
- Look for duplicate content issues — e-commerce sites frequently create duplicate pages through URL parameters, faceted navigation, and product variant pages

Schema Markup for E-Commerce

Structured data (schema markup) tells Google and AI systems exactly what information is on your page — product name, price, availability, reviews, brand. Without it, Google has to infer this information. With it, you get rich results in search (star ratings, prices, availability shown directly in the search listing) and you give AI systems the structured information they need to accurately recommend your products.

Priority schema types for e-commerce:

- Product schema: name, description, price, availability, brand, SKU
- AggregateRating schema: your review score and review count
- BreadcrumbList schema: your site navigation structure
- FAQPage schema: the questions and answers on your category pages

Internal Linking Architecture

E-commerce sites often have poor internal linking — product pages exist as isolated islands with no connection to category pages, blog content, or brand pages. A strong internal linking structure distributes authority throughout your site and helps both Google and AI systems understand your site's topical structure.

THE QUICK WIN MOST BRANDS MISS

Run a free crawl of your site using Screaming Frog (free for up to 500 URLs) or Sitebulb. The output will almost certainly reveal broken links, missing meta descriptions, duplicate title tags, and uncompressed images — all of which are suppressing your rankings right now. Fix these before investing in any content strategy. You are building on sand until the technical foundation is solid.

Action Checklist: Strategy 6

1. Check Core Web Vitals scores in Google PageSpeed Insights for your homepage, top category page, and top product page.
2. Run Google Search Console for crawl errors and resolve the top five.
3. Implement Product and AggregateRating schema on all product pages.
4. Run a site crawl and fix broken internal links, duplicate title tags, and missing meta descriptions.

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Strategy 7

Measure, Report, and Grow

The brands that grow are the brands that track

The biggest mistake e-commerce brands make with SEO and AEO is not tracking anything. They invest in content, fix technical issues, build some PR — and then have no idea whether it is working. When results come (and they do come, slowly), they cannot connect the improvement to a specific action. When results do not come, they cannot diagnose why.

Building a simple measurement framework is one of the highest-leverage things you can do for your long-term organic growth.

The E-Commerce Visibility Dashboard

You need to track four categories of metrics. You do not need expensive tools to start — Google Search Console and Google Analytics 4 cover the fundamentals for free.

Metric Category	What to Track and Why
Organic traffic	Total sessions from organic search, by landing page. This is the headline number — are more people arriving from search over time?
Keyword rankings	Your position for your top 20 target keywords. Track weekly. Look for movement on pages 2 and 3 first — these are your fastest wins.
Organic revenue	Revenue attributed to organic search in GA4. This connects your SEO investment directly to commercial outcomes — the number your MD cares about.
AI visibility checks	Monthly manual check of your top 10 AI recommendation queries. Are you appearing? Are competitors? Is your share growing? This cannot be automated yet — do it manually.

The 90-Day Reporting Cadence

SEO is a long game, but it is not an invisible one. In 90 days of consistent implementation, you should see:

- Movement in rankings for pages two and three keywords (weeks four to eight typically)
- Improvement in Core Web Vitals scores after technical fixes
- Increase in organic impressions (Google Search Console) even before rankings move significantly
- First AI search appearances — even partial or occasional mentions — for lower-competition queries

Set a monthly review date. Sit with the data. Ask: which pages improved? Which actions drove that improvement? What should we prioritise next month? This discipline separates the brands that compound organic growth year over year from those that plateau indefinitely.

When to Bring in Specialist Help

The strategies in this guide are actionable for in-house teams with marketing bandwidth. But there are two points at which specialist help creates disproportionate value:

- Technical SEO — site architecture, schema markup, Core Web Vitals optimisation. The mistakes here are easy to make, hard to spot, and expensive to leave unfixed. A technical SEO audit from a specialist pays for itself quickly.
- AEO strategy — understanding precisely how AI systems evaluate and recommend brands in your category, and building the right content and PR strategy to capture those recommendations. This is a newer discipline and the expertise is scarce. Agencies that combine traditional SEO with AEO specialisation are rare — and currently hold a significant advantage for their clients.

A WORD ON ROI

E-commerce brands are accustomed to paid traffic, where every click has a measurable cost and return. Organic traffic is different — the payback period is longer (typically 3–9 months to see significant results) but the lifetime value is dramatically higher. A page-one Google ranking for a commercial keyword drives traffic indefinitely, for years, for free. An AI recommendation that names your brand generates referred traffic at zero marginal cost. The brands that understand this arithmetic and invest accordingly are the ones that eventually reduce their ad dependency and protect their margins.

Action Checklist: Strategy 7

1. Set up Google Search Console and Google Analytics 4 if you have not already.
2. Define your 20 target keywords and start tracking them weekly.
3. Create a simple dashboard spreadsheet: organic traffic, organic revenue, top keyword rankings, AI visibility checks.
4. Book a monthly 30-minute review date in your calendar. Review the data. Make a decision. Implement.

Your Next Step: The Free AI Search Visibility Audit

You have just read 7 strategies for building organic visibility that compounds over time, reduces your paid ad dependency, and positions your brand as a trusted recommendation across both Google and AI search.

Now here is the honest truth: knowing the strategies is not the hard part. The hard part is knowing exactly where your brand stands right now — and what the specific, prioritised actions are to close the gap.

That is what the free AI Search Visibility Audit gives you.

What the Audit Includes

- Your current Google rankings for your top 10 product and category keywords — and where your competitors are ranking for the same terms
- A full AI search visibility check across ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Google AI Overviews — tested against the specific recommendation queries your customers are using
- A competitor comparison: which brands in your category are already winning AI search recommendations, and what they are doing differently
- The top 3 specific, prioritised actions that would have the greatest impact on your visibility in the next 90 days

The audit is delivered within 48–72 hours as a short Loom video walkthrough plus a one-page PDF summary. No jargon. No sales pitch. Just real intelligence about your business that you can act on immediately.

Book your free AI Search Visibility Audit at gmaxdigitalsolutions.com

If after receiving the audit you want Gmax to implement the changes — we offer a 90-day SEO + AEO Sprint at a fixed price, followed by an optional monthly retainer. No long-term contracts until you have seen results. The audit tells you what to fix. The Sprint fixes it.

The brands that own AI search recommendations in 2027 are building that position today.

Gmax Digital Solutions

SEO + Answer Engine Optimisation for UK E-Commerce Brands

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